Morgan Wack

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POSITIONS

Postdoctoral Scholar, University of Zurich 2024 – Present
Department of Communication and Media Research (IKMZ)

Research Assistant Professor, Clemson University 2023 – 2024
Media Forensics Hub

Research Associate, University of Washington 2020 – 2023
Center for an Informed Public

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Political Science, University of Washington 2023
M.A., Political Science, University of Washington 2021
M.Sc., Government, London School of Economics 2016
B.A., Sociology, Colorado College 2015

HONORS AND FELLOWSHIPS

Visiting Fellow at the Centre for Information Integrity in Africa (CINIA) 2026
Top Paper Award, ICA 2026 Global Communication & Social Change Division 2026
Top Paper Award, ICA 2026 Political Communication Division 2026
Election Integrity Partnership Fellowship 2022
Richard S. Wesley Scholarship, University of Washington 2022
Craig Newmark Fellowship, University of Washington 2022
Best Paper Award, ACM SIGCAS Conf. on Computing and Sustainable Societies 2020
Foreign Language and Area Studies (FLAS) Fellowship 2020
Paul Speyer Fellowship, University of Washington 2019
Peter May Fellowship, University of Washington 2018

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Publications

1. **Wack, M.**, Pipal, C., & Vogel, E.-M. "Do citation limits constrain diversity? Evidence from a natural experiment across political science journals." (Accepted – *PS: Political Science and Politics*).

2. **Wack, M.*** & Prochaska, S.*. (2026). "Making sense of AI-generated disinformation: How audience interpretations influence the impact of deepfakes in Kenya." *Social Media + Society,* 12(3). *Equal contributors.

3. **Wack, M.**, Allan, J., Boatwright, B., & Cranmer, C. (2026). "Assessing how fact-checks influence accuracy and consensus judgments: Evidence from the Olympics." *Risk Analysis*, 46(7).

4. Pipal, C., **Wack, M.**, Profos, A. A., Vogel, E.-M., Wittstock, N., & Mpadanes, M. (2026). "When does self-correction work for LLMs in content analysis? The role of external structure and task complexity." *Computational Communication Research*, 8(2).

5. **Wack, M.**,* Duskin, K.,* & Hodel, D. (2026). "Political Fact-Checking Efforts are Constrained by Deficiencies in Coverage, Speed, and Reach." *Political Communication*, 1-24. *Equal contributors.

6. Jalbert, M.* & **Wack, M.*** (2026). "Intuitions about content moderation are misaligned with effective practices for reducing conspiracy beliefs." *Communications Psychology.* *Equal contributors.

7. **Wack, M.** & Parry, D. A. (2025). "Synthetic diversity: Examining the effects of ethnic targeting using AI-generated political ads." *International Journal of Communication*, 19, 3736–3760.

8. Saucier, C. J., **Wack, M.**, Linvill, D., Okoronkwo, A., Tatineni, G., & Sezgin, A. (2025). "Content camouflage: How diversified posting patterns influence human detection of AI-enabled social bots." *Computers in Human Behavior*, 108881.

9. **Wack, M.***, Schafer, J. S.*, Kennedy, I., Beers, A., Spiro, E. S., & Starbird, K. (2025). "Legislating uncertainty: Election policies and the amplification of misinformation." *Policy Studies Journal*. *Equal contributors.

10. **Wack, M.**, Linvill, D., Ehrett, C., & Warren, P. (2025). "Generative propaganda: Evidence of AI's impact from a state-backed disinformation campaign." *PNAS Nexus*, 4(4).

11. **Wack, M.**, Magistro, B., & Aslett, K. (2025). "Silence in the stands: Assessing the impact of Russian sportswashing on online fan behavior following the full-scale invasion of Ukraine." *Social Science Quarterly*. 106(1), e13485.

12. Parsons, S., Kennedy, I., Bentley, Q., & **Wack, M.** (2025). "Telling my sons how Angel Reese stood toe to toe with the KKK and won: Colorblind racism and intersectionality in sports discourse on social media." *Sociology of Race & Ethnicity*.

13. Schafer, J. S., Duskin, K., Prochaska, S., **Wack, M.**, Beers, A., Bozarth, L., Agajanian, T., Caulfield, M., Spiro, E. S., & Starbird, K. (2025). "ElectionRumors2022: A dataset of election rumors on Twitter during the 2022 U.S. midterms." *Journal of Quantitative Description: Digital Media*, 5.

14. **Wack, M.** & Jalbert, M. (2024). "Social truth queries as a novel method for combating misinformation: Evidence from Kenya." *International Journal of Press/Politics*.

15. Jalbert, M., **Wack, M.**, Arya, P., & Williams, L. (2023). "Social truth queries: Development of a new user-driven intervention for countering online misinformation." *Journal of Applied Research in Memory and Cognition*.

16. Magistro, B. & **Wack, M.** (2023). "Racial bias in fans and officials: Evidence from the Italian Serie A." *Sociology*, 57(6), 1302–1321.

17. Beers, A., Schafer, J. S., Kennedy, I., **Wack, M.**, Spiro, E. S., & Starbird, K. (2023). "Followback clusters, satellite audiences, and bridge nodes: Coengagement networks for the 2020 US election." In *Proceedings of the International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media*, 17, 59–71.

18. Bak-Coleman, J., Kennedy, I., **Wack, M.**, Beers, A., Schafer, J. S., Spiro, E., Starbird, K., & West, J. (2022). "Combining interventions to reduce the spread of viral misinformation." *Nature Human Behaviour*, 1–9.

19. Kennedy, I.*, **Wack, M.***, Schafer, J. S., Beers, A., Spiro, E., & Starbird, K. (2022). "Repeat spreaders and election delegitimization: A comprehensive dataset of misinformation tweets from the 2020 U.S. election." *Journal of Quantitative Description: Digital Media*, 2. *Equal contributors.

20. Zade, H.*, **Wack, M.***, Zhang, Y., Schafer, J. S., Beers, A., Starbird, K., Calo, R., & West, J. (2022). "Auditing Google's search headlines as a potential gateway to misleading content: Evidence from the 2020 U.S. election." *Journal of Online Trust and Safety*, 1(4). *Equal contributors.

21. Ziegler, M., **Wack, M.**, Ingutia, N., Muiruri, I., Njogu, N., Muriithi, K., Njoroge, W., Long, J., & Heimerl, K. (2020). "Can phones build relationships? A case study of a Kenyan wildlife conservancy's community development." In *Proceedings of the 3rd ACM SIGCAS Conference on Computing and Sustainable Societies*, 219–230. **Best Paper Award at ACM SIGCAS.**

Book Chapters

1. **Wack, M.**, Mudavadi, K., & Jalbert, M. (2025). "Election observer statements and domestic perceptions of election integrity." In *Election Observation at a Crossroads*.

2. **Wack, M.** & Kharazian, Z. (*Forthcoming*). "Existential threat or moral panic? Synthesizing debates about disinformation's impact." In *The Handbook of Disinformation and the Media*.

3. Vogel, E.-M., Pipal, C., **Wack, M.**, & Esser, F. (*Forthcoming*). "Who are the news influencers? Origins of fame and the boundary with journalism in the 2024 U.S. presidential election." In D. Schill & J. A. Hendricks (Eds.).

Manuscripts Under Review

1. Erickson, M.* & **Wack, M.*** "Assessing how shifts in global demand for natural vanilla influenced crime in Madagascar." (R&R). *Equal contributors.

2. **Wack, M.** "A collaborative digital field study shows how community-led interventions can minimize engagement with election falsehoods." (R&R). Pre-print: https://osf.io/preprints/socarxiv/sek9h_v1. **Top Paper Award, ICA 2026**

3. **Wack, M.**, Warren, P., & Alam, M. "The laziness of the crowd: Selective attention among raters risks undermining the efficacy of X's Community Notes program." (R&R). Pre-print: https://arxiv.org/abs/2603.11120.

4. Blessing, J.,* **Wack, M.**,* & Mahl, D.* "AI Can Correct but Not Convince: Epistemic Authority and Emotionalized Communication in TikTok Health Misinformation Corrections." (R&R) *Equal contributors. Pre-print: https://osf.io/preprints/socarxiv/vzxd6_v1

5. Pipal, C., Vogel, E.-M., **Wack, M.**, & Esser, F. "Researchers waste 80% of LLM annotation costs by classifying one text at a time." (R&R). Pre-print: https://arxiv.org/abs/2604.03684.

6. **Wack, M.**, Vogel, E.-M., Pipal, C., & Warren, P. "Fact-checks can help inoculate LLMs against disinformation." (R&R). Pre-print: https://osf.io/preprints/socarxiv/nrs5z_v1.

7. **Wack, M.** & Wittstock, N. "Signals of weakness? Blatant electoral fraud and perceived regime support among connected Nicaraguans." (R&R).

8. **Wack, M.,** Vogler, D., Arrigo, M., Pipal, C., & da Silva, L. P. "Who sees politics in sports? Norm endorsement and partisan judgments from the 2026 World Cup." (Under Review). Pre-print: https://osf.io/preprints/socarxiv/gtjp4_v1.

9. **Wack, M.**, Pipal, C. & Manda. "Pricing out dissent: Online content regulations and political attitudes in Tanzania." (Under Review).

10. **Wack, M.** & Paulsen, T. "Does democracy die in darkness? Electricity outages and electoral accountability in South Africa." (Under Review).

11. **Wack, M.**, Jadoon, A., & Lokmanoglu, A. "How the Channel of Protest Coverage Conditions Its Political Effects: Evidence from South Africa." (Under Review)

12. Walker, C.*, Birrer, A.*, **Wack, M.***, Schiff, K.*, Schiff, D.*, & Messina, J. P. "Beyond deception: A new typology of political deepfakes." (Under Review). *Equal contributors. Pre-print: https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=5717943.

13. Pipal, C., **Wack, M.**, & Vogel, E.-M. "Who gets counted? Using large language models to close coverage gaps in name-based demographic classification." (Under Review).

14. Pipal, C., **Wack, M.**, & Vogel, E.-M. "How rare is political content among social media influencers? Evidence from election and routine periods." (Under Review). **Top Paper Award, ICA 2026**

15. da Silva, L. P., Schincariol, T., & **Wack, M.** "Football empires: Simulating the effects of colonialism on the 2026 World Cup." (Under Review). Pre-print: https://osf.io/preprints/socarxiv/awy9x_v1.

16. **Wack, M.**, Vogel, E.-M., Pipal, C., & Labarre, J. "AI-assistance in public comments widens participation but erodes their usefulness." (Under Review).

17. **Wack, M.**, Vogel, E.-M., & Pipal, C. "Nice try, ChatGPT: How AI accusations are used to dismiss opponents and divert political debates." (Under Review).

18. **Wack, M.** & Warren, P. "Fact-check? True!: Tracking verification requests and the absence of truth verdicts across correction systems." (Under Review). Pre-print: https://arxiv.org/abs/2610.17068.

Manuscripts in Preparation

1. **Wack, M.** & Vogel, E.-M. "LLMs Default to Official State Statistics, Even When the Numbers Are Contested."
2. **Wack, M.**, Vogel, E.-M., & Pipal, C. "Biased provision: How LLMs and search engines differentially enable confirmatory evidence collection."
3. **Wack, M.**, Jalbert, M., & Long, J. "Courting controversy: Judicial decisions, trust, and misinformation in elections."

Registered Reports

1. **Wack, M.**, Hoes, E., Vogel, E.-M., Pipal, C., & Esser, F. "Curating quality information: A randomized controlled trial of social media activation." Stage 1 Registered Report, in preparation for Nature Human Behaviour (2027 Kenyan general election).

Public Reports and Front-Facing Articles

1. Esser, F. and Solis, J.A. and Chan, M. and van Aelst, P. and Madrid-Morales, D. and Bosch, T. and Botan, M. and Humprecht, E. and Labarre, J. and Santini, R.M. and Schulz, A. and Seim, B. and **Wack, M.** and Howard, P.N. and Valenzuela, S. (2026). Resilience and Vulnerability to Misinformation and Disinformation in Political Information Environments: A Comparative Review of Ten Indexes. IPIE Technical Paper.
2. **Wack, M.**, et al. (*Under Review*). A New Information Environment Diagnostic for the IPIE Conceptualization, Operationalization, and Application. IPIE Technical Paper. Expected October 2026.
3. **Wack, M.**, Walker, C., Birrer, A., Schiff, D., Schiff, K., & Messina, J. P. (2025). Scrutinizing the many faces of political deepfakes. Tech Policy Press.
4. **Wack, M.** & Schafer, J. (2025). The 2020 U.S. election shows how state election policies can fuel conspiracy theories about voting. LSE Phelan U.S. Blog.

5. **Wack, M.** (2024). AI propaganda campaign in Rwanda has been pushing pro-Kagame messages. The Conversation.

6. **Wack, M.**, Linvill, D., & Warren, P. (2024). Old despots, new tricks: An AI-empowered pro-Kagame/RPF coordinated influence network on X. Media Forensics Hub Reports, 5.

7. Long, J., **Wack, M.**, & Menaldo, V. (2021). Prosecuting ex-presidents for corruption is trending worldwide. The Conversation.

8. Starbird, K., et al. (2021). The Long Fuse: Misinformation and the 2020 election. Election Integrity Partnership, Stanford Digital Repository.

9. **Wack, M.**, Buckley, N., Schafer, J., & Zhang, M. (2020). Inconsistencies in state-controlled media labeling. Election Integrity Partnership.

GRANTS AND AWARDS (in USD)

2026 UZH Graduate School Travel Grant, PI, $2,600

2026 UZH Graduate School Short Grant, PI, $5,600

2026 Community Building Research Grant Award, Co-PI, $11,300

2024 Google Research Inclusion Award, "Understanding and Co-Designing Responsible Generative AI Tools with Historically Marginalized Communities in South Africa and Kenya", PI, $60,000

2024 Clemson Media Forensics Strategic Project Fund, "Win, Lose, or Disinform?", Co-PI, $18,000

2023 UW CIP Innovation Fund, "Synthetic Media and Public Trust", PI, $8,898

2023 UW iSchool Strategic Research Fund, Co-PI, $15,283

2022 Institute for Data, Democracy and Politics Research Fellowship, Co-PI, $19,600

2022 UW CIP Innovation Fund, Kenya 2022 Election Project, Co-PI, $10,886

Grants Under Review

Internet Society Foundation Research Award (2026), "*From Connectivity to Citizenship: A Cluster Randomized Trial of Rural Internet Access and Civic Participation in Madagascar*", Co-Investigator, $198,000, under review

European Research Council Starting Grant (2026), "Public Adaptation to Unverifiable Information Environments: Individual, Collective, and Institutional Responses to Generative AI" (UNVERIFIABLE), Principal Investigator, University of Zurich, €1,500,000, under review

FWF ASTRA Award (2026), "The Post-Verification Public: Epistemic Adaptation under Synthetic Media Saturation", Principal Investigator, University of Vienna, €999,519, under review

Recent Media Coverage

1. "We tested how AI chatbots would handle foreign propaganda. They did surprisingly well." *NPR*.

2. "Tell me lies…" *Forbes*.

3. "When Everything is Circulating at the Same Time: Why Fact-Checking is no Longer Enough" *Ground Zero*.

4. "The misinformation accelerator: To misinformation researchers, AI is a scourge, and a powerful new tool." *Science*.

5. "A Russian fake news ring was struggling. Then it targeted USAID." *The Washington Post*.

6. "AI image from the White House goes viral." *Deutsche Welle.*

7. "Russian propaganda campaign used AI to scale output without sacrificing credibility." *PsyPost.*

8. "As Iran and Israel fought, people turned to AI for facts. They didn't find many." *GPB News.*

9. "Elon Musk said he'd eliminate bots from X. Instead, election influence campaigns are running wild." *Rest of World.*

10. “How misinformation ‘superspreaders’ seed false election theories.” *The New York Times.*

RECENT INVITED TALKS AND CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Recent and Upcoming Invited Talks

1. **Wack, M.** (2026). “Defaulting to the State: When (and Why) LLMs Repeat Contested State Statistics.” GRAIL Lab, Purdue University. October 2026.
2. **Wack, M.** (2026). “Resolving Political Uncertainty: How AI-Connected Technologies Reshape Sensemaking, Opinion, and Behavior.” UCT AI Lab, University of Cape Town. July 2026.
3. **Wack, M.** (2026). “Disinformation in Elections: Lessons and Warnings.” Media Monday Series, Department of Journalism, Stellenbosch University. July 2026.
4. **Wack, M.** (2025). “Does democracy die in darkness? Electricity outages and electoral accountability in South Africa.” Invited Researcher Series, Nuffield College, University of Oxford. December 2025.
5. **Wack, M.** (2025). “External price shocks, state capacity, and violence from Madagascar’s vanilla industry.” Invited Researcher, Department of Politics, University of Strathclyde. December 2025.
6. **Wack, M.** & Parry, D.A. (2024). “Synthetic diversity: Examining the effects of ethnic targeting using AI-generated political ads.” Linde Center for Science, Society, and Policy (LCSSP) Workshop, Caltech. October 2024.

RECENT AND UPCOMING CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

1. **Wack, M.** & Warren, P. “Laziness of the crowd: How cognitive constraints impair crowdsourced moderation.” Annual Meeting of the American Political Science Association (APSA). September 2026.
2. **Wack, M.** & Prochaska, S. “Making sense of AI-generated disinformation: How audience interpretations influence the impact of deepfakes.” Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA). June 2026.
3. **Wack, M.** “Assessing the influence of community-led interventions on reductions in election falsehoods: Experimental evidence from South Africa.” Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA). June 2026.
4. Walker, C., Birrer, A., **Wack, M.**, Schiff, K., Schiff, D., & Messina, J. P. (2026). “Beyond deception: A functional typology of political deepfakes.” Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA). April 2026. *Equal contributors. Presented by Walker.
5. **Wack, M.**, Warren, P., & Alam, M. (2026). “Optimal Allocation of Fact-Checking Resources on Long-Term Prevalence of Online Misinformation.” 24 Hours of Political Psychology, University of Vienna.
6. **Wack, M.** (2026). “Inefficiencies in Crowdsourced Moderation: How Consensus Drives Conspiracies.” SGKM Annual Conference 2026.
7. **Wack, M.**, Vogel, E.-M., & Pipal, C. (2026). “Do Reference Limits Constrain Diversity? Using LLMs to Improve Name Classification.” COMPTEXT Annual Conference on Computational Text Analysis 2026.
8. **Wack, M.**, Pipal, C., & Vogel, E. (2025). “Trust in the digital age: News influencers, political misinformation, and audience perceptions.” ECREA Political Communications, Innsbruck, Austria. September 2025.
9. **Wack, M.**, Pipal, C., & Vogel, E. (2025). “Trust in the digital age.” Amsterdam Trust Summit, University of Amsterdam. August 2025.
10. **Wack, M.** (2025). “Contextualizing the threats (and opportunities) presented by political deepfakes.” Computational Visual Methods and Research Symposium (CVMR), University of Zurich. August 2025.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record

1. University of Zurich, "Digital Technologies and Political Discourse" (Fall 2026). Undergraduate Seminar.
2. Clemson University, POL S 3050/Creative Inquiry, "Win, Lose, or Disinform? Understanding Misinformation in Times of Crisis" (Spring 2024). Undergraduate Seminar.

Discussion Section Lead and Teaching Assistant

1. University of Washington, POL S 362, Data, Technology, & Development in Africa (Spring 2022).
2. University of Washington, POL S 371, Global Crime & Corruption (Winter 2020).
3. University of Washington, POL S 307/RELIG 207, Religion & World Politics (Winter 2019).
4. University of Washington, LSJ 320/POL S 368, International Human Rights (Autumn 2019).

STUDENT MENTORING AND SUPERVISION

1. PhD Supervision: Doctoral student in Communication, University of Zurich.
2. PhD Colloquium Lead: Division of Comparative and International Media Research, University of Zurich (2024–Present).
3. MA Thesis Supervision: multiple students at the University of Zurich and Clemson University.
4. Research Seminar Coordinator: Center for an Informed Public, University of Washington (Summer 2021, Summer 2022).
5. Publication Support: I have led the conduct of several research projects alongside graduate students at UW, Clemson, and Zurich as a coordinating mentor.

SERVICE AND PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Research and Policy Service

1. Consulting Scientist, Indexing Panel, International Panel on the Information Environment (IPIE) (2025 –Present).
2. Consultant, National Democratic Institute (NDI), Kosovo Disinformation Framework (2024).
3. Member, USAID Research Technical Assistance Center (RTAC) (2024–Present).
4. Affiliate, Center for Information, Technology, and Public Life (CITAP) (2024–Present).

Departmental and Professional Service

1. Department Mittelbau Representative, IKMZ, University of Zurich (2026-Present).
2. PhD Colloquium Coordinator, Division of Media Use & Effects, University of Zurich (2024–Present).
3. Department Social Media Coordinator, IKMZ, University of Zurich (2024–Present).
4. Treasurer, Equality Initiative in Political Science (EIPS) (2022-2023).
5. Center Coordinator, UW Political Economy Forum (2021–2023).
6. Workshop Host: Influencer Communications Workshop, University of Zurich (March 2026).
7. Co-Organizer, Annual Digital Publics Conference, University of Zurich (October 21–23, 2026).

Recent Journal Reviews

American Political Science Review; Political Behavior; Political Communication; British Journal of Political Science; Human Communication Research; International Journal of Human–Computer Interaction; Science Advances; Social Network Analysis & Mining; New Media & Society; AI and Ethics; Computers in Human Behavior; Creator & Influencer Studies; Discover Artificial Intelligence; Discover Global Society; Humanities & Social Sciences Communications; Journal of Information Technology & Politics; Social Networks

PEDAGOGICAL & METHODS TRAINING

1. Didactica Teacher Training Program, University of Zurich (2024–Present).
2. GESIS Workshop, Machine Learning for Text Analysis with Python (2025).
3. UW Center for Statistics and the Social Sciences (CSSS), Advanced Concentration Certificate.

SKILLS, LANGUAGES, AND AFFILIATIONS

Programming: R, Python, NVivo, Qualtrics, SurveyCTO, ArcGIS.

Languages: English (native), Spanish (intermediate), German (basic).

Affiliations: CINIA (Stellenbosch), Center for an Informed Public (University of Washington), Media Forensics Hub (Clemson University), CITAP (University of North Carolina), USAID RTAC, EIPS Board.